

DON'T DUCK YOUR DESTINY

**BLUE DENOTES POWER POINT
SLIDE**

**BROWN DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS
TO TECHNICIAN**

INTRO: (Duck Dynasty Video)

This series is a takeoff of the highly rated reality television program, Duck Dynasty. Rather than talking about Duck Dynasty, I want to talk about not ducking your destiny.

Everyone was sent into this world for a purpose. Not one person who has ever entered the world is an accident, no matter what your parents say!

You are here for a purpose.

I suppose all of us have had moments where we have dreamed of greatness. (Most young people imagine themselves becoming great.)

(Larissa talking to her mother about what she wanted to be – How long does it take to become a doctor, a teacher, a hairdresser...? Life is like a big drum – you have to beat out your own rhythm...!)

Almost everyone begins life with visions and dreams of greatness, but along the way most of us become convinced to live a sub-par or mediocre existence. Why? There are probably more reasons than there are people! (A failure to make the grade in school – Being told they will never amount to anything – Being made a victim – A failed marriage – The death of a child – The termination of employment...)

While everyone has a destiny, few achieve it and many become convinced to live a sub-par existence.

For the next few weeks I want us to think about our destiny - why we believe we were

permitted to be on this earth; born to our family of origin; given the opportunities we have been afforded; confronted with the obstacles we have been forced to face.

In short, why are we here and what are we supposed to be doing? I want to throw out what I believe to be a life changing truth: Every single human being has been sent into the world for a Divine purpose! **2 Timothy 1:8-9 (CEV) “*Don’t be ashamed to speak for our Lord. And don’t be ashamed of me, just because I am in jail for serving him. Use the power that comes from God and join with me in suffering for telling the good news. 9 God saved us and chose us to be his holy people. We did nothing to deserve this, but God planned it because he is so kind. Even before time began God planned for Christ Jesus to show kindness to us.”*** Jeremiah 29:11 (NKJV) “*For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says*

the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”

If our existence is no accident, then we must believe God has an eternal purpose for us.

The fulfillment of our destiny is to live out the purpose of God on this earth, and hear Him say “well done” at the successful conclusion of our earthly sojourn!

In an attempt to learn how to completely fulfill our destiny, I want to focus on a man named Abraham and his story as it is stated in nineteen verses of the Old Testament book of Genesis, chapter twenty-two.

Genesis 22:1-19 (NKJV) “Now it came to pass after these things that God tested Abraham, and said to him, ‘Abraham!’ And he said, ‘Here I am.’² Then He said, ‘Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt

offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.’ 3 So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.4 Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.5 And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’6 So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.7 But Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, ‘My father!’ And he said, ‘Here I am, my son.’ Then he said, ‘Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?’ 8 And Abraham said, ‘My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering,’ so the two of them went

together. 9 Then they came to the place of which God had told him. And Abraham built an altar there and placed the wood in order; and he bound Isaac his son and laid him on the altar, upon the wood.10 And Abraham stretched out his hand and took the knife to slay his son.11 But the Angel of the LORD called to him from heaven and said, 'Abraham, Abraham!' So he said, 'Here I am.'12 And He said, 'Do not lay your hand on the lad, or do anything to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from Me.'13 Then Abraham lifted his eyes and looked, and there behind him was a ram caught in a thicket by its horns. So Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering instead of his son.14 And Abraham called the name of the place, The-LORD-WILL-PROVIDE; as it is said to this day, 'In the Mount of The LORD it shall be provided.' 15 Then the Angel of the LORD called to

Abraham a second time out of heaven,16 and said: ‘By Myself I have sworn, says the LORD, because you have done this thing, and have not withheld your son, your only son 17 blessing I will bless you, and multiplying I will multiply your descendants as the stars of the heaven and as the sand which is on the seashore; and your descendants shall possess the gate of their enemies.18 In your seed all the nations of the earth shall be blessed, because you have obeyed My voice.’19 So Abraham returned to his young men, and they rose and went together to Beersheba; and Abraham dwelt at Beersheba.”

The successful fulfillment of Abraham’s destiny can be captured in the following five ways:

- Sensitivity
- Submission
- Separation
- Sacrifice

- Stuff

I want to begin this series of sermons by looking at the sensitivity Abraham displayed along the road of pursuing his ultimate destiny.

I. SENSITIVITY

The path to fulfilling our destiny begins with sensitivity. We must learn to be:

- Sensitive to God
- Sensitive to others
- Sensitive to our surroundings

In Genesis, chapter twelve, we are introduced to a man by the name of Abram. Abram was a man who feared the Lord and had a heart to follow God. Abram's destiny is spelled out in **Genesis 12:1-3 (NKJV)**

“Now the LORD had said to Abram: ‘Get out of your country, from your family and from your father’s house, to a land that I will show you. 2 I will make you a great

nation; I will bless you and make your name great; and you shall be a blessing. 3 I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse him who curses you; and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.’”

Abram’s destiny is admittedly somewhat vague, but certainly powerful and far-reaching. Because of the realization of his destiny, Abram became the father of the Jewish race, and an ancestor of Jesus Christ. Because of this, Abram’s destiny is alive and being fulfilled even in our time.

God told Abram to go out and look for a city; He didn't tell him which one, but He told him when he found it he would know it. The Bible says ***“He looked for a city which had foundations whose builder and maker is God”!***

God was not being disingenuous to Abram by not telling him where He was taking him;

God had Abraham enrolled in sensitivity training! Because of what God told Abram regarding the city he was taking him to, he had to treat each city as if it were the one!

Much later (at 99 years old), Abram receives a divine revelation, a confirmation of the promise, and name change. For the first time, Abram received specific instructions concerning the land that he was to possess.

Genesis 17:4-8 (NKJV) “... *Behold, My covenant is with you, and you shall be a father of many nations.*⁵ *No longer shall your name be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham; for I have made you a father of many nations.*⁶ *I will make you exceedingly fruitful; and I will make nations of you, and kings shall come from you.*⁷ *And I will establish My covenant between Me and you and your descendants after you in their generations, for an everlasting covenant, to be God to you and your descendants after you.*⁸ *Also I give to*

you and your descendants after you the land in which you are a stranger, all the land of Canaan, as an everlasting possession; and I will be their God.”

In order to reach his destiny, Abraham had to learn to be sensitive! Sensitivity is not imparted, it is learned through experience. (Have someone to come up and make only two or three chords – Then have someone, an experienced musician, come up and play the song.)

It was important that Abraham learn to be sensitive because later he would have to find the right mountain on which to offer his son, and even more important, he would need to be sensitive enough to find a ram that would die in place of his son!

Abraham's life was marked by questions like:

- Which direction?

- Which country?
- Which city?
- Which mountain?

The greatest proof of Abraham's sensitivity is revealed in Genesis 22:2-3 (NKJV) when God said to him, *“Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.”* 3 So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.”

Tony Robbins said, *"It is in moments of decision that your destiny is shaped."* This moment of decision defined the life of Abraham. There will be a handful of moments that will define who each of us are.

Abraham did not pull against God and declare that God was being unfair. He trusted God and was sensitive enough to obey.

If you and I are going to achieve our destiny, we must learn to be sensitive to God, sensitive to others, and sensitive to our surroundings.

We must realize that God has a master plan for our life. This master plan is replete with details - from our mom and dad's bedroom to the funeral parlor. God carefully planned every day of our life before we were a twinkle in our father's eye!

God's master plan for our life is not a fast track or overnight success story; it is a process that is intended to end with success. Hebrews 10:36 (NKJV) ***"For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done***

the will of God, you may receive the promise:”

From the time I began Pastoring, I began praying “*Lord, help me to be sensitive to the moving of your Holy Spirit.*” Being sensitive to the Holy Spirit has provided direction, prevented potential problems, averted traps, and avoided pitfalls in my life!

Do you see how important it is to be sensitive? The realization of our destiny depends on it - both physically and spiritually!

The fulfillment of Abraham’s destiny was dependent on the level of his sensitivity.

We cannot fulfill our destiny without being sensitive. Anger, frustration, bitterness, strife, etc., are enemies of sensitivity. (Story about frustrated preacher)

When these things are permitted entry into our life all progress toward our destiny ceases.

Are we going to be satisfied with living in a stunted growth process, or are we going to commit ourselves to being sensitive to God, sensitive to others, and sensitive to our surroundings, thus allowing for the fulfillment of our destiny?

II. SUBMISSION

The life of Abraham is a perfect picture of submission to the authority of God and to the authority of man. God called Abraham to go, but failed to specify where.

Abraham held a garage sale, told his family good-bye, pulled up the stakes of his tent and went on an expedition of following God. Abraham seems to have done all of this almost without a second thought. How could he go without being furnished more detail?

He was able to do such a thing because he was living his life in total submission to God.

Abraham also proved his submission to man in the fact that he was almost too timid in dealing with his family and the Kings who hosted him during his expedition of finding the will of God. (His demeanor in dealing with Lot – His handling of he and Sarah’s relationship with Abimelech – She was the daughter of his father, but not of his mother)

Of all the times Abraham was called upon to submit either to man or God, the greatest test of his submission must have been the call of God to sacrifice his son Isaac.

Genesis 22:1-2 (NKJV) *“Now it came to pass after these things that God tested Abraham, and said to him, ‘Abraham!’ And he said, ‘Here I am.’² Then He said, ‘Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of*

Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.’”

The first question that comes to mind every time I read this passage of Scripture is: How could God ask a man who has exercised such faith and submission to do such a thing?

All the other times Abraham was called upon to exercise faith and submission must have paled in the face of this test. All the other tests were the proving ground for what would occur on the top of Mt. Moriah. This was to be the greatest test of Abraham's submission and confidence in God. This incident would no doubt put to the test the belief that God had a destiny that he was taking Abraham to. The questions running through Abraham's mind probably sounded like this:

- How can I become a Father of Nations without a son?
- How can I have the number of descendants that had been predicted, without a son?
- How can I be a blessing to succeeding generations without a son?
- How could a thing like this be of God?

This test would no doubt define Abraham's life: when you hear Abraham spoken of, it is rare that this test is not mentioned; when writing to the Hebrews, Paul could not resist the temptation to mention this test. [Hebrews 11:17-19 \(NKJV\)](#) ***“By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises offered up his only begotten son, 18 of whom it was said, ‘In Isaac your seed shall be called,’ 19 concluding that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead, from which he also received him in a figurative sense.”***

If Abraham could pass this test, everything else would be academic. (Small stuff – don't sweat the small stuff – remember, everything is small stuff when God is involved)

Notice [Genesis 22:3 \(NKJV\)](#) *“So Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.”* Look at this:

- No argument...
- No hedging...
- No fleeces...

Abraham just arose the next morning and started splitting the wood, greasing the wagon wheels, choosing which servants he would take with him, and informed his son they were going to a father and son conference on Mt. Moriah!

Wow! What confidence and submission!
Most of us would have needed to be dragged
up Moriah by the hair of the head! We
would have gone:

- Kicking and screaming...
- Raising multiple objections...
- Stating all kinds of theological questions...
- Telling God how wrong child abuse would be...

We would have raised more sand than the
alligator did the day the pond went dry!

Abraham did nothing of the sort; he had
perfected the art of submission before he
ever left Egypt. While at Moriah, his
submission would move him one giant step
closer to his ultimate destiny.

Abraham knew he was destined to be the
Father of Nations. As a result, he knew

nothing but his own disobedience could stand between him and his destiny.

Therefore, he believed that if God required him to go through with killing his son and cremating him on the altar of sacrifice, that God would raise him from the ashes of the fire of sacrifice. [Hebrews 11:17-19 \(NKJV\)](#) *“By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises offered up his only begotten son, 18 of whom it was said, ‘In Isaac your seed shall be called,’ 19 concluding that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead, from which he also received him in a figurative sense.”*

The opposite of submission is rebellion. Rebellion is simply a lack of submission. The Bible reveals some strong statements with regard to rebellion. [1 Samuel 15:23 \(NKJV\)](#) *“For rebellion is as the sin of*

witchcraft, and stubbornness is as iniquity
and idolatry.”

Submission serves as a voltage regulator for our mind, will, and emotions! It protects us against power surges!

Submission does for us what a governor does to a vehicle:

- It keeps us accountable...
- It keeps our actions and reactions at a safe level...
- It prevents us from running at such high RPM that our other faculties cannot keep pace...
- It paces us so that more can be accomplished over the long haul...

Submission and accountability are good things not bad things! The Centurion said to Jesus, ***“I am a man under authority”***! He did not say ***“I am a man in authority”*** he said ***“I am a man under authority, and I***

say to one servant, go, and he goeth, and to another come, and he cometh.” Has it ever occurred to you that the centurion was saying, ***“I am a man under authority; as a result I do not live in fear of my underlings challenging my authority, because they know if they do not submit to my authority they will have to deal with the person that I am submitted to; therefore, I say to my servant go, and he goeth...”***

Before you can be a person OF authority, you must be a person UNDER authority! (A young pastor fresh out of Bible College said to my youth pastor, “I skipped the youth pastor level and went straight to being a senior pastor!” The Youth Pastor went home and told the Children’s Pastor, “I skipped the Children’s Pastor level and went straight to being a Youth Pastor!”)

Rebellion is a lack of submission. I am quite sure that most of the people in this building

today would not think of using an ouguiya board, tarot cards; consult a psychic; a witch; a warlock; or a fortuneteller to find the will of God!

None of us would ever attend a church that would allow such things, yet people set on our pews Sunday after Sunday doing something far worse, they are in rebellion! They are rebelling because they are not under submission!

God has commanded us to be submitted vertically and horizontally.

Some of us do not have a problem getting used to the idea of submitting to God, after all, he holds our very breath in his hand. Yet we seem to struggle greatly with horizontal submission.

I am convinced the prevention of destiny in the life of most Christians is an issue of

horizontal submission rather than vertical submission!

There are two times we are called upon to submit: when we feel like it and when we don't; when we understand and when we don't.

I am quite sure Abraham neither felt like submitting nor did he understand what he was being called upon to do. Yet he submitted to the voice of the Lord and immediately obeyed. His submission, confidence, and obedience guided him through the most difficult trial of his life and allowed him to emerge as a hero of the faith!

You may very well be walking through the most difficult trial of your life - if so, God has a plan for your celebration of victory!

Remember, just as Abraham of old, the reason you are being called upon to face this

trial is that God is attempting to define your life and preparing you to occupy the destiny He is calling you to.

Never forget, all the small trials serve to prepare you for a great trial, and the successful navigation of the really BIG ONE will usher in the promise of God and the blessing of the Lord. (When we celebrated our seventh anniversary, Susan was so relieved she said if she missed the rapture she knew she would not have to go through the tribulation because she had already been through it) (A guy once told me that he thought I was the Antichrist; because the Scripture said he would wear out the saints of the most high)

What are the options when faced with a trial such as this? Either submit or take the course over!

Can you imagine Abraham having to go to Moriah until he got it right? Moriah is only to be climbed once in a lifetime!

Your Moriah may be:

- A wayward child...
- A cheating spouse...
- An illness...
- A financial collapse...

Whatever you face today, remember, God is in control the whole day through!!!

III. SEPARATION...

Genesis 22:4-6 (NKJV) *“Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off. 5 And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’ 6 So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire*

in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.”

It is interesting to me that at the point of Abraham’s greatest trial, he was obedient enough to the words of the Lord that he was able to call his response to the seemingly ridiculous command of God, worship!

Faced with similar circumstances, most of us would have:

- Demanded better treatment...
- Complained to the pastor...
- Gathered a coalition of supporters...
- Quit the church...
- Backslid altogether...

Abraham was no quitter; he was a courageous man of faith who refused to be controlled by the circumstances of the moment - rather looking to the eventuality of the journey!

Those who choose to place too much emphasis on the circumstances at hand tend to suffer from chronic discouragement and are normally underachievers.

Underachievers rarely go to mountaintops because they are so accustomed to much lower altitudes where defeat and pity are never more than one battle away!

Most people are guilty of allowing their problems to eclipse their promise! (Have everyone to close one eye and place their thumb in front of their face while observing an object... Have them move their thumb to arms length and look again...)

I want to ask a question of every person in this place: Are we placing too much emphasis on the circumstances of the moment, or are we focused on the eventuality of the journey?

The answer to this question will have much bearing on whether or not we achieve the destiny God has called us to, or if we will duck our destiny.

To this point Abraham has been called upon to exercise more sensitivity, submission, and separation than most people are asked to exercise throughout an entire lifetime.

The bottom line is, during Abraham's expedition of finding the will of God and achieving his destiny, he reached a point where he and Isaac had to separate themselves from the crowd! [**Genesis 22:6 \(NKJV\) “*So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.”***](#)

Separation has been championed in the church for centuries. We have been told to separate ourselves from the world and the people who choose to live according to its

system. We are not called to separate ourselves from the world; we are called to detest the world's system while loving God and loving the people who are hopelessly trapped in this world's system.

Please understand I believe in sanctification and Holy living, but the church must find a way to make inroads into the culture it is called to reach.

It is my opinion that the Word of God teaches a doctrine of relevance without compromise. Relevance without compromise is a belief that we must be relevant in our culture without compromising the message we preach!

Here is what relevance without compromise should look like in the twenty first century church;

- The church develops friendships with those who are lost...

- The church determines the needs of its target audience and makes a commitment to meet them...
- The church shows the love of Christ in tangible ways...
- The church demonstrates to sinners they are loved while refusing to participate in their sin...
- The church preaches a strong message of repentance without being overbearing in the process of modeling and application...

Recently I spoke to a staff member of a charismatic/Pentecostal church who told me they had quit giving altar calls because they did not want to offend those who were new in the church!

If you go to a bar this Saturday night, do you think they will require all those present to refrain from consuming alcoholic beverages to keep from offending you? Not on your

life! The church must continue to preach a strong message, but be innovative in the process of modeling and application.

The church of the past century had two major problems that must be corrected in this twenty first century if we are to become what God has intended us to be;

- It was extremely slow to accept change... Because we live in the information age, the church must be capable of foreseeing paradigm shifts and adjust its ministry to facilitate the trends as they are happening. What if Abraham had waited twenty years to respond to what God had asked of him? He would have probably talked himself out of actually going to Moriah with his son, reasoning this sacrifice was probably unnecessary.
- Once it began to change it had a tendency to overcompensate... Going from one extreme to the other is not the answer. We must develop a ministry

plan that is consistent and actually works! Overcompensation can be as counterproductive as no change at all! What if Abraham had concluded that if God wanted him to kill his son, it would please God even more if he killed every male in his house?

Our methods must be continually changing, but our message and determination to change the culture must never change!

Another aspect of this story is the fact Abraham and Isaac were accompanied to the mountain by a group of servants.

Nowhere does the Bible say that the servants requested to go to the mountain with Abraham! Genesis 22:4-6 (NKJV) ***“Then on the third day Abraham lifted up his eyes, and saw the place afar off. ⁵ And Abraham said unto his young men, Abide ye here with the ass; and I and the lad will***

go yonder and worship, and come again to you. ⁶ And Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering, and laid it upon Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife; and they went both of them together.”

Trust me, if I had made this long, grueling journey to the mountain, I would be more difficult to leave behind than just being told one time to stay with the donkeys.

These servants are a little too easy to leave behind! If they had Abraham’s best interest at heart, they would have been jumping up and down to accompany him and the lad to the summit! If they were the kind of servants that had his back, he could not have gone alone!

I am about to share with you a leadership lesson, that if followed, will accelerate your

destiny, and if ignored will certainly impede or maybe even prevent your destiny:

- Everyone does not desire to go to your mountain...
- Everyone does not intend to go to your mountain...
- Everyone is not called to your mountain...

We spend far too much time and resources attempting to carry unwilling people up the mountainside! I spent the first twenty years of my pastoral ministry attempting to drag unwilling participants up my mountain! (Illustrate this)

If you want to go to our mountain, you are more than welcome. If you don't want to go, stay here with the donkeys, or find you a different mountain to climb or a group of people who like hanging out at low altitudes! (If you want to soar with eagles, quit roosting with turkeys!) (I will not beg

you to stay, or refuse your resignation)
(What about the good shepherd and the one lost lamb? It was a lamb, not a full grown sheep!)

Can you imagine what would have occurred if Abraham had attempted to physically carry Isaac, his servants and the wagon to the mountain top? He, no doubt would have tired of the journey, collapsing in one big heap of burnout and failed to carry out the plan of God!

While Abraham would have been working hard to get to the mountain top, he would have failed to reach the place of sacrifice, thus bringing him into disobedience and judgment! (Plus I would not have had anything to preach on today!)

How many good people do you suppose have fallen prey to this trick?

The devil doesn't have to get you to fall into gross sin to prevent the destiny in your life, all he has to do is distract you with busyness that prevents you from making a move on your destiny.

If those you have been traveling with are not going to the same mountain you are going to, leave them behind and continue your pursuit! Kiss them goodbye, bless their STABLE aspirations, and keep climbing! (Did you hear about the horse that fell with the jockey? The last time I heard a report they were both in STABLE condition)

In the pursuit of his destiny, Abraham ascended to a height his servants could not attain. He had to separate himself from them and keep on climbing!

If you have a destiny you are focused in on, there WILL come a time where separation will occur. The top of the mountain is

sparsely populated, but it's worth the cost of the climb! (The 10 spies - The man on whose hand the king leaned)

IV. SACRIFICE...

Genesis 22:2-13 (NKJV) *“Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.⁴ Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.⁵ And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’⁶ So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.⁷ But Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, ‘My father!’ And he said, ‘Here I am, my son.’ Then he said, ‘Look, the fire and*

the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?’ 8 And Abraham said, ‘My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering,’ so the two of them went together. 9 Then they came to the place of which God had told him. And Abraham built an altar there and placed the wood in order; and he bound Isaac his son and laid him on the altar, upon the wood.10 And Abraham stretched out his hand and took the knife to slay his son.11 But the Angel of the LORD called to him from heaven and said, ‘Abraham, Abraham!’ So he said, ‘Here I am.’12 And He said, ‘Do not lay your hand on the lad, or do anything to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from Me.’13 Then Abraham lifted his eyes and looked, and there behind him was a ram caught in a thicket by its horns. So Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering instead of his son.”

Abraham and Isaac are an unusually close father and son duo. Abraham was one hundred years old when Isaac was born. Because of a very bad decision a few years earlier, Abraham found himself in a situation of sending Hagar and Ishmael away. Because of this, he probably tried to compensate for that loss through Isaac. Isaac was no doubt Abraham's pride and joy, the apple of his eye; he no doubt thought the sun rose and set in Isaac.

I can imagine seeing them hiking up the side of this mountain talking about the things fathers and sons talk about (fishing – hunting - hiking – camping). All of a sudden it begins to dawn on Isaac that they do not have a sacrifice and he inquires of his father as to its whereabouts. (Kids can be extremely inquisitive – Larissa inquiring about her and Jason's birthdays).

Pay close attention to the inquiry of Isaac and the response of Abraham. [Genesis 22:7-8 \(NKJV\)](#) *“Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, ‘My father!’ And he said, ‘Here I am, my son.’ Then he said, ‘Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?’” And Abraham said, ‘My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering.’ So the two of them went together.”* Isaac was so confident of his father’s leadership and ability to deliver on his promises, that you don’t hear one more word about the whereabouts of the sacrifice! I wonder how confident we are about our Father’s ability to make good on the destiny to which He has called us?

Little did Isaac know that he would be involved in a very personal way in the provision of the sacrifice! Your destiny will probably never be realized until it has exacted from you a very high personal price.

(Story of chicken and pig – No pain, no gain)

This sacrifice would exact a high price from Isaac but would exact an even higher price from Abraham. Abraham was perfectly willing to give up Isaac in his pursuit of being in the perfect center of the will of God!

A lot of people think that this was not too difficult for Abraham because Abraham believed that if he killed Isaac, that God would raise him from the dead! Maybe so, in fact the scripture says that he believed God would do exactly that.

We must realize that Abraham had never witnessed a resurrection. There is no evidence that he had ever heard of a resurrection. Everything that had ever died or left Abraham's life was a permanent departure, never to return:

- He left home and never went back...
- Lot took the best of everything and never returned...
- Hagar and Ishmael made an exit and never came back...

Have you ever considered, even if God raised Isaac from the dead, what emotional and relational damage would have been done between Abraham and Isaac from that day forward? Trust would probably be a thing of the past – from that day forward every time Abraham put Isaac in a headlock, Isaac would have a panic attack thinking he was going to break his neck. Once the sacrifice was made, even if there was a resurrection, Abraham and Isaac could never return to a normal father and son relationship.

Abraham was willing to give up his relationship with his promised son to be where God wanted him to be!

It is extremely rare that anyone achieves a destiny without strapping a sacrifice to the altar. Most of us will be called upon by God to place multiple things on the altar of sacrifice in order to attain His higher purpose.

The question must be asked, how much sacrifice is enough? The answer is until there is no chance of our being lifted up in pride when we stand victoriously on the summit of our success!

T.D. Jakes said, *“The only way you will ever know how bad you want it, is to determine how much you are willing to give up to get it!”*

The price of sacrifice is never small – otherwise it would not be a sacrifice!

It would be no sacrifice at all to me to give up eating cheese, but it is a tremendous sacrifice to fast ten days.

For us to stand on the summit of our destiny, we will likely be called upon to sacrifice something we love!

In the book of Judges, Chapter eleven, we are introduced to a man by the name of Jephthah. Jephthah was conceived from a union between his father and a prostitute.

The Bible says that Jephthah was a mighty man of valor. When Jephthah's father and his wife had children and they grew up, those sons threw Jephthah out of the house. Jephthah grew up in a dysfunctional household:

- A cheating father...
- A jealous stepmother...
- Angry half-brothers...

At some point, the Ammonites began to threaten the land and all of a sudden Jephthah was a hot commodity again!

Every great leader goes through times of isolation:

- Moses...
- Elijah...
- John the Baptist...
- Jesus...
- All of us...

The very half-brothers that threw Jephthah out now negotiate a deal with him that if he would consent to leading the nation in a successful war effort, they would make him the leader of the land.

Evidently Jephthah's tough upbringing made a fierce warrior out of him to the point that when the nation was in crisis, there was no doubt as to who could lead it out!

You may feel you have been:

- Abused...
- Alienated...
- Mistreated...
- Ostracized...

I am here today to announce to you, God intends to make you the head and not the tail – in His good time!

Before Jephthah went to battle he prayed to God, and during that prayer he made a vow to God that would exact from him a sacrifice of unprecedented proportions. [Judges 11:30-31 \(NKJV\)](#) *“Jephthah made a vow to the LORD, and said, ‘If You will indeed deliver the people of Ammon into my hands, 31 then it will be that whatever comes out of the doors of my house to meet me, when I return in peace from the people of Ammon, shall surely be the LORD’s, and I will offer it up as a burnt offering.’”*

Jephthah went to battle against the Ammonites, and God miraculously delivered them into his hand. Notice what happened when Jephthah returned home from the battle: [Judges 11:34-35 \(NKJV\)](#)

“When Jephthah came to his house at Mizpah, there was his daughter, coming out to meet him with timbrels and dancing;

(I can remember when I was no more than 3 or 4 years old, waiting at the end of the driveway for my dad to come home from work. When I heard his panel van coming, my heart rate began to quicken and the excitement was almost more than I could bear. Dad would stop and let me ride on the running board of that panel van back to the house) ***and she was his only child. Besides her he had neither son nor daughter. 35 and it came to pass, when he saw her that he tore his clothes, and said, ‘Alas, my daughter! You have brought me very low! You are among those who trouble me! For***

I have given my word to the LORD, and I cannot go back on it.”””

Achieving your destiny will not always be comfortable or easy. Sir Edmund Hillary made several unsuccessful attempts at climbing Mt. Everest before he finally succeeded. After one attempt he stood at the base of that giant mountain and shook his fist at it. In defiance he said *“I’ll defeat you yet because you’re as big as you are going to get, but I’m still growing.”*

Though climbing to the peak of your destiny will not be easy, your stay at the top will be worth the climb.

Abraham and Jephthah believed the sacrifice would be worth the result, do we?

Despite the enormous difficulty, Abraham did not duck his destiny – Jephthah did not duck his destiny – what will our excuse be?

What would you be willing to sacrifice to go to the mountain peak of your destiny? Trust me, if we actually achieve the destiny we are called to, we will have to strap something we love to an altar of sacrifice. In doing so, we must be confident that what God will give us in return will be better than what we given up!

V. STUFF...

Genesis 22:2-13 (NKJV) *“Abraham rose early in the morning and saddled his donkey, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went to the place of which God had told him.⁴ Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.⁵ And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’⁶ So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son;*

and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.7 But Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, 'My father!' And he said, 'Here I am, my son.' Then he said, 'Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?' 8 And Abraham said, 'My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering,' so the two of them went together. 9 Then they came to the place of which God had told him. And Abraham built an altar there and placed the wood in order; and he bound Isaac his son and laid him on the altar, upon the wood.10 And Abraham stretched out his hand and took the knife to slay his son.11 But the Angel of the LORD called to him from heaven and said, 'Abraham, Abraham!' So he said, 'Here I am.'12 And He said, 'Do not lay your hand on the lad, or do anything to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from Me.'13 Then Abraham

lifted his eyes and looked, and there behind him was a ram caught in a thicket by its horns. So Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering instead of his son.”

Webster defines the word stuff in the following ways:

- Basic elements...
- The material out of which anything is or can be made...

Not everything in our life comes in nice neat and expensively wrapped packages. Most things require some assembly. (Going to IKEA with Susan)

Abraham and Isaac had the...

- Wagon, the wood, and the fire...
- The transportation, the fuel, and the passion...
- The courage, the determination, and the resolve...

The only thing they lacked was the sacrifice! Abraham said, “***God will provide for himself a sacrifice.***” Notice he did not say that God would provide Abraham or Isaac a sacrifice, he said, “***God will provide Himself a sacrifice.***” Abraham did not organize or call this meeting; God did, so the sacrifice or resurrection was God’s problem.

All Abraham and Isaac needed was:

- The ear to listen...
- The hands to help...
- The heart to respond...

If Abraham and Isaac would provide these three ingredients, God would lead them step-by-step into a holy setup!

This world’s system says:

- We need a handout...
- We need an entitlement...

- We need someone to come running to our rescue...

We don't need a handout! We need a setup! A handout is being given something you neither worked nor planned for. A setup is something you have participated in from the beginning!

Abraham and Isaac had participated in this setup from the beginning:

- They readied the wagon and donkeys...
- They split the wood...
- They selected the servants...
- They packed the gear...
- They made the trip...
- They climbed the mountain...

Can you see a Divine setup about to transpire? As we read this story:

- The anticipation begins to build...
- The expectancy begins to rise...

- The adrenalin begins to flow
- The sense of the miraculous teeters precariously on the edge...

We just know God is about to do something supernaturally spectacular.

Abraham could not see the ram until the moment of desperation. He had to be faithful in each step of the journey and at the breaking point the miracle would reveal itself. If we will be faithful in spite of the pain and the problems God will set us up for victory!

If we fail the faithfulness test we will have to settle for a handout! A handout can be:

- A banker...
- A lawyer...
- A doctor...
- A preacher...
- A marriage counselor...

Any of these folks can orchestrate a handout, but it takes Divine intervention to bring about a setup!

Not everyone can participate in a setup. Some folks are predisposed to mess-up a set-up! I believe God spoke to me and said the reason Abraham did not take his servants, and the reason they never asked to go is because they would have interfered, rather than participated in the setting of the stage for the miracle and act of Divine love God was about to demonstrate to his FRIEND Abraham!!

People who are more comfortable with a handout than a setup will:

- Crash rather than climb...
- Complain rather than confess...
- Sit rather than shout...
- Get bitter rather than better...

Isaac said, *“Father, here is the wood, and here is the fire, but where is the sacrifice?”*

The manner in which Isaac saw the circumstances is much different than the way Abraham sees them. What is the difference? T.D. Jakes said *“A boy can see the stuff, but a man knows how to put it all together!”* (The Swing set)

God has given us the stuff, all we have to do is put it all together according to his instructions, and within his timing.

Even a man must have the help of the Lord in putting all of the pieces together, thus unveiling the picture God had in mind from the beginning!

God knew me before I was born, and planned each day of my life and He has graciously provided all the pieces to get from here to Glory!

God provided for Abraham the stuff for a sacrifice but it was up to him to put it all together. This wasn't a handout it was a setup!

Abraham and Isaac reached the summit of their mountain, and Abraham built the altar and placed the wood in order, he then placed his arm around his son and gently explained to his son what was about to happen!
(Illustrate this)

Abraham planned to sacrifice his son, but God had another plan. When he raised the knife to take the life of his son, God spoke to him about a ram caught in a thicket behind him!

A ram is uniquely designed to negotiate briar patches without being trapped by them! What in the world is wrong with this ram?

Nothing was wrong with the ram, he just had an overactive GPS!

This ram had not experienced a lack of stamina it was a holy stakeout! God tied the ram by his horns in the thicket so Abraham would have a substitute!

Think about it, Abraham had stomped all over this mountain getting just the right rocks and this ram never made a sound? This was a holy stakeout!

I believe Abraham was so glad to see this ram that he felt like kissing him right on the lips in spite of the fact that the ram had chronic halitosis!

Have you ever been there? God provided a substitute for you! A ram for a son, a son for a sin! There is no better substitute!

Abraham was sensitive enough to hear at a moments notice. How far in advance does God have to start speaking to us to bring about a minor change? The lead-time is no doubt much longer for a major change.

Is God free to pull off a setup in us at a moments notice? In order to receive a setup rather than a handout we have to be capable of transitioning at a moments notice. Miracles are made in moments of transition and flexibility!

Abraham had offered dozens if not hundreds of sacrifices and not one time had God taken one sacrifice down to offer a different sacrifice. What would have happened if Abraham had been too traditional to transition?

Some of us can't receive a holy setup because we strapped the wrong sacrifice to the altar in the beginning and we can't

accept the fact that God had something else in mind!

Most of us need less tradition and more transition!

Businesses fail, nations crumble, marriages end in divorce, careers are brought to an abrupt halt, denominations lose their effectiveness, ministries die, churches decline, people backslide because of an inability to transition! Some people would rather fight than switch! (Use old commercial!) (Story about Swiss watchmakers refusing to adapt to the quartz watch - Has led to sharing a very small part of the market, and extremely reduced profit margins)

CONCLUSION:

When we are involved in a holy setup we will discover our sacrifice tied up in a stakeout, and when we make that discovery

we will realize that the only thing we contributed to the final outcome was:

- Being sensitive to God, our fellow man, and our surroundings...
- Being in submission to authority, both human and Divine...
- Separating from the company of those who are not going to our destiny...
- Sacrificing the things that must be sacrificed...
- Receiving and assembling the stuff God has provided for the trip...

Our substitute is waiting in the wings; he has been tied up and is awaiting our discovery!

If we can find our substitute we will discover the stuff to bring our dream to fruition!